

# 2023 Accelerator Cohort

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COMBINED RESEARCH ANALYSIS | NOVEMBER 2023

## Introduction

As part of the 2023 Local News Initiative Accelerator Program, Northwestern University's Medill School of Journalism, Media, Integrated Marketing Communications performed market research on behalf of five different Chicago-area news organizations: the Illinois Answers Project, the Daily Herald, La Raza, City Bureau and Crain's Chicago Business. Using a combination of email listservs, social media outreach and targeted surveys conducted by Qualtrics, Medill collected information from more than 3,600 respondents. These respondents provided a diverse cross-section of the Chicago news consumer, and allow for holistic insights into the demographics, habits and values of an engaged audience.

Of particular value is a historical comparison with data from earlier years. In 2021, Medill collected more 2,300 responses from readers residing in Chicago's South and West Sides. With the addition of data from the City Bureau survey, Medill was able to round out the geographic scope of the respondents, enabling an analysis of trends over time in readership consumption and habits.

Included in this report are summaries of the individual surveys and their findings, a profile of the respondents, changes in news readership and news engagement and suggested opportunities for cultivating that engagement. In our analysis, we identified three key findings that emerged when placing these different surveys in conversation with one another:

1. **A clear eagerness for local news.** Local news is an important part of the overall news consumption of this audience. Interest in local news and local reporting are increasing, and trust in local news is strong within this cohort, especially when compared against findings from previous years and national trends.

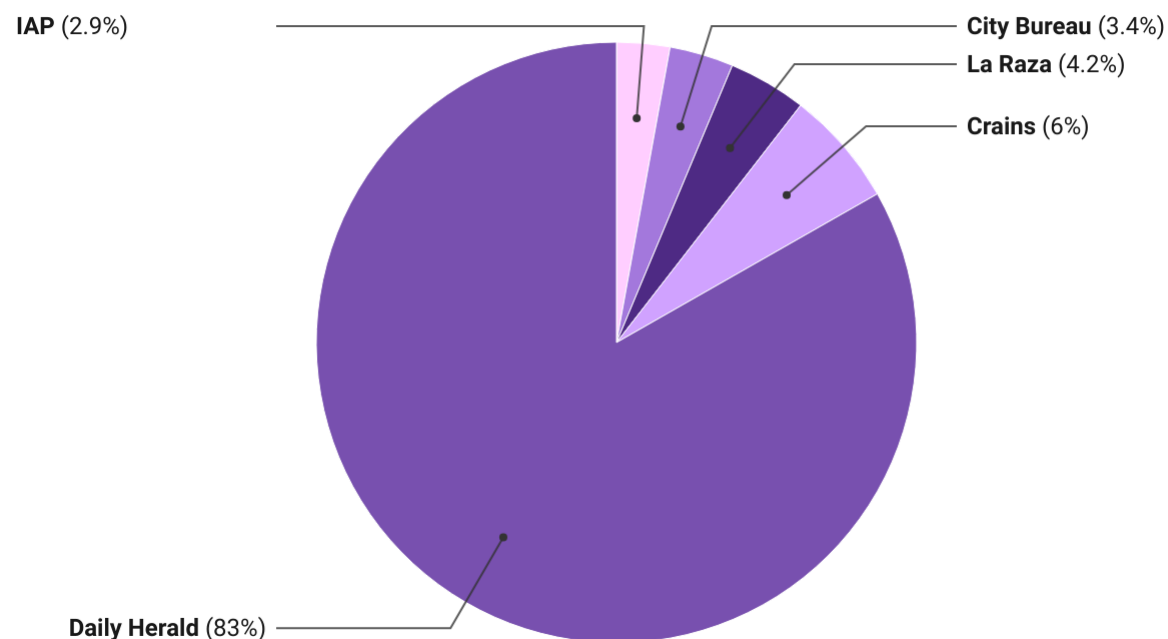
2. **A willingness to pay for local news.** In a departure from previous survey results, many members of this audience are motivated to pay for local news, and indeed, reflect this with paid subscriptions to multiple news outlets.
3. In line with the previous two findings, **many of the shortcomings or deficiencies observed by respondents in the coverage of local issues focus on coverage, frequency, rather than predominantly trust issues.** This reflects a belief in the value of local news and a desire for its expansion in covering topics of importance.

In preparing this analysis, we are grateful to the researchers at Qualtrics for helping connect us with a greater variety of respondents, and to all the members of the 2023 Accelerator cohort for their passion, interest and drive.

## Survey Overviews

We received more than 3,600 responses to the surveys we distributed across all five organizations. However, in the distribution of these responses, more than 80% came from surveys conducted by the Daily Herald. This disparity was expected, given the sheer size of the mailing list that the Daily Herald used for to circulate the survey (118,000 people, for a response rate of almost 3%).

## Distribution of Responses



For all surveys, however, we received roughly 100 or more responses, giving us a robust dataset to explore for each organization. When taken together, random sampling allows us to mitigate the undue weight of the Daily Herald response bloc, and create a holistic portrait of the cohort news consumer and their habits. As individual datasets, the responses can also tell us much about specific and varied kinds of audiences.

Each survey consisted of two parts: a core set of questions common to all five cohort members, and a set of questions tailored to each specific organization — specifically related project each undertook through the Medill Local News Accelerator. The common questions, which were the same across all surveys, asked a series of demographic and news consumption questions, ranging from age and income to what times of the day people typically engaged with local news. By combining these common questions together from the different surveys, a perspective of the average audience member begins to emerge. These questions were also chosen and written to mirror those asked in 2021, allowing for a historical comparison.

## Survey Overviews

This research is based on surveys of five Chicago area news organizations:



### **Daily Herald**

The Daily Herald received 3,031 total responses to their surveys. As an organization with a large existing audience of older readers, the Daily Herald was particularly interested in learning more about their younger readers, in order to more effectively reach a target audience of young families.



### **Crain's Chicago Business**

Crain's Chicago Business collected 218 responses from its newsletter mailing list. Crain's goal in surveying its audience was to gain insights that might help to support the expansion of their Data Center Product.

## LaRaza

### La Raza

La Raza received 144 responses to its bilingual surveys: 34 in English and 114 in Spanish. These results were complemented by five hours of focus-group interviews with existing La Raza customers, in order to learn more about its current readership and help discover new ways of reaching additional readers. La Raza focused especially on second-generation immigrants.



### Illinois Answers Project

The Illinois Answers Project collected roughly 100 responses to the surveys that it distributed to its mailing lists and circulated on social media.



### City Bureau

In targeted surveys conducted by Qualtrics, City Bureau collected 118 respondents, particularly from geographical areas in Chicago that they were aiming to reach.

### News on Chicago's South and West Side - 2021

In 2021, Medill and Qualtrics conducted a survey of South and West Side Chicago readers, and gathered more than 2,300 results. For the purposes of this report, this data will be used for background and historical comparison, rather than combined with the data from the 2023 Accelerator cohort.

## Who Responded?

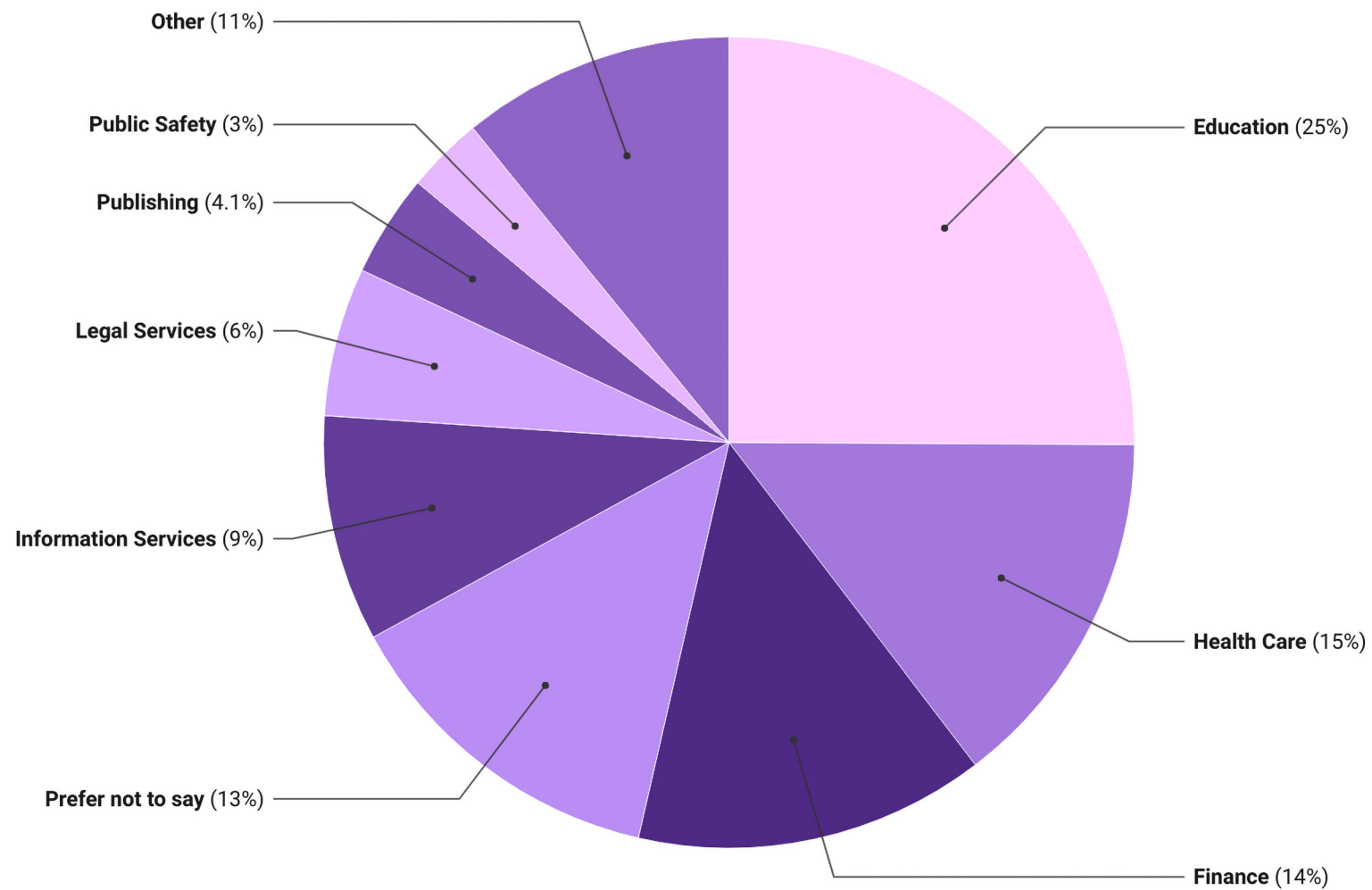
The demographic profiles of the respondents varied according to which organization's survey they were responding to. For example, the respondents of the Daily Herald skewed older in age, while City Bureau's tended younger, and La Raza's were more evenly distributed. By comparing these results to one another, however, we can gain insight into a general cohort audience member.

### **General Demographics:**

The 2023 Accelerator cohort reaches a demographically diverse population. A majority of respondents across all surveys, and a majority of respondents in three of the five individual surveys, identified as female. Although a majority of respondents identified their race or ethnicity as white, Hispanic/Latinx were also strongly represented, followed by African Americans and Asians, reflecting the multicultural shifts of both the city as a whole as well as the specific areas where responses were coming from. In a weighted sample, nearly 40% of respondents identified themselves as a non-white. Diversity is even higher among younger members of this cohort: among respondents younger than 34 years old, 43% identified themselves as non-white.

On the whole, the audience of this cohort is very well-educated. In a weighted sample of all surveys, more than two-thirds of respondents reported themselves as possessing a bachelor's degree or higher. In two out of five of the individual surveys, nearly 90% of respondents reported having a bachelor's degree or higher. This cohort is relatively high-income as well; over half of respondents reported an annual household income greater than \$75,000, compared to the Illinois state average of \$72,563, and the Cook County average of \$72,121. On average, this cohort tends to live in households of two to three people. Among those who specified, nearly a quarter reported that they worked in the education sector, followed by health care, finance, and information services.

## Industries of Respondents





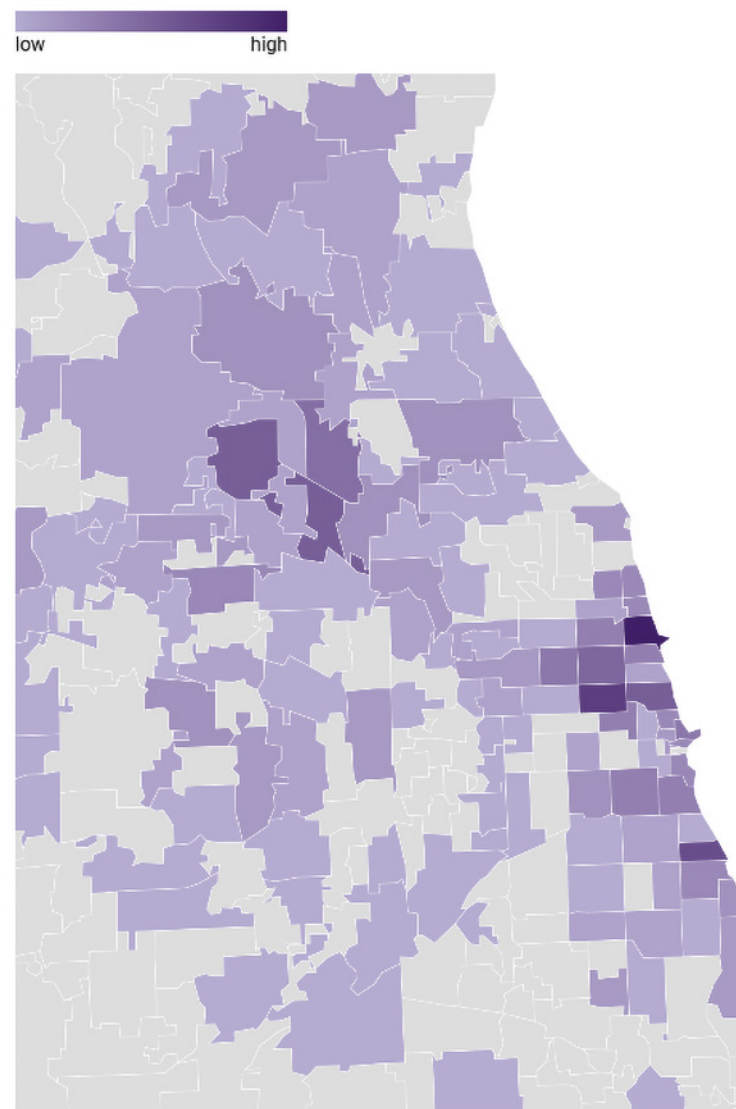
**Geography:**

The 2023 Accelerator Cohort had a geographically well-rounded audience. Several different areas of Chicagoland were well represented in the results: from the city, particularly high concentrations of readers reported themselves as living in the community areas of Uptown, Logan Square, Lincoln Park, Hyde Park, and Near North Side. The suburbs to the north and northwest were also well-represented; including Arlington Heights and Palatine.

**Readership Habits:**

According to a recent Pew Research Report, Americans are reporting lower and lower engagement with news. Between 2016 and 2022, the share of U.S. adults saying they followed the news “all or most of the time,” dropped from 51% to just 38%. Even more concerning, nearly a third of adults in 2022 said that they follow the news only now and then, or not at all.

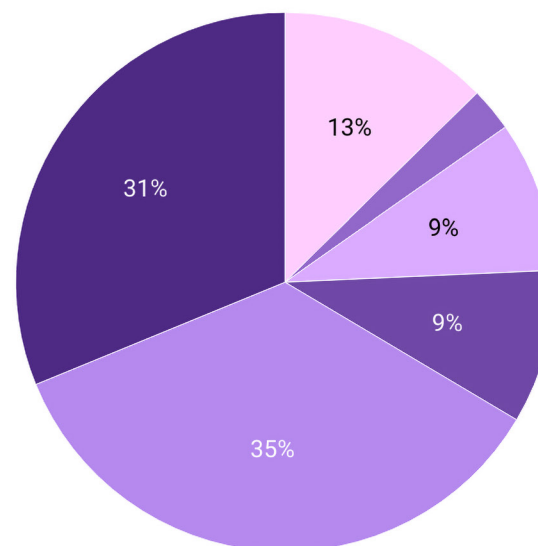
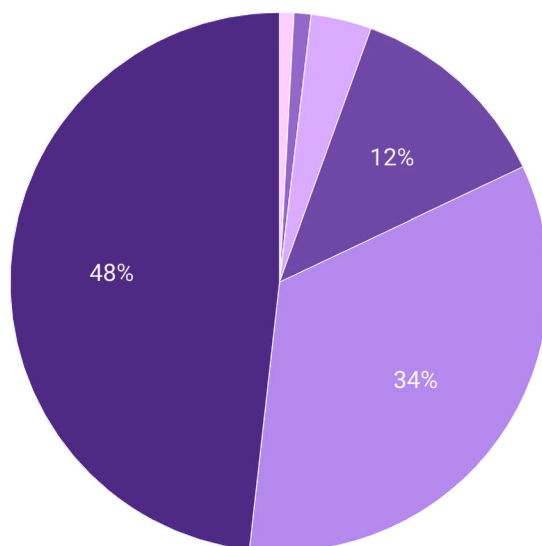
However, in a departure from that statistic, it **is clear from the survey responses that this cohort’s audience is particularly invested in local news.** Across all surveys, less than ten percent of respondents said that they were consuming

**Zip Code Distribution of Responses**

local news less than they were in the previous year. Although this number remained generally consistent across all types of news (local, international, etc.), the percentage of respondents consuming news less frequently was lowest for local Chicago and Illinois state news, compared to other categories. Local news in particular is an important part of respondents' news consumption: More than 80% indicated that they checked stories about their local community at least once a day. Interest in local news is also growing: Roughly 20% of respondents indicated that they were consuming local news *more* than they were in the previous year. This is corroborated by the change in local news consumption between what was reported in this year's survey and in 2021. In the latter, only 66% of respondents indicated that they checked stories about their community at least once a day.

## News Consumption Frequency

Almost Never Once a month Once a week A few days a week More than once a day Once a day



In addition, more than 90% of respondents indicated that they use a Chicago area news source as part of their regular news engagement.

## What Sources do Readers Use?

Chicago Area Newspaper and National Sources   Other Chicago Media and National Sources   Chicago Area Media Exclusively  
National Media Exclusively



Trust in local news sources is high, and remains so compared to previous years. More than half of all respondents indicated that they trust local news sources the most, compared to less than 25% who chose national news outlets. This is slightly higher than the trust levels reported in 2021; more strikingly, trust in local news has remained consistently strong

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**Compared to the rest of the country, these high levels of trust among the cohort's audience are especially encouraging; a recent Gallup poll found that, across the United States, high levels of trust in news media have dropped to just 32%, matching the previous record low in 2016. In contrast to this national decline in trust in news media, trust levels among the 2023 Accelerator cohort remain strong, especially towards local news organizations.**

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even while trust in other news sources (in particular, news coming from social media) has declined. More than 75% of all respondents indicated that they trust news about the same or more highly than they did last year. Compared to the rest of the country, these high levels of trust among the cohort's audience are especially encouraging; a recent Gallup poll found that, across the United States, high levels of trust in news media have dropped to just 32%, matching the previous record low in 2016. In contrast to this national decline in trust in news media, trust levels among the 2023 Accelerator cohort remain strong, especially towards local news organizations.

We asked participants to choose the issues that were the most important facing their neighborhood, and that local news should be providing coverage of. Respondents identified eight issues, listed here in order from most to least important:

1. Crime and Law Enforcement
2. Environment
3. Education
4. Health Care
5. Housing, Zoning, and Land Use
6. Business and Employment
7. Transportation
8. Cultural Opportunities

We also asked readers to rate the quality of coverage that they felt their local news source was providing about these issues. In terms of sentiments towards coverage quality, respondents indicated that their local news organizations did the best job in covering cultural opportunities, and crime and law enforcement issues, while the least effective coverage was observed in Housing, Education, and Health Care.

### Coverage Gaps:

We asked respondents to identify, if they felt there was a shortcoming in the way that a topic was being covered by local news media, what that shortcoming was. These were open response questions, and we received over 1200 individual responses. The most common sentiments in each category were:

|                                      |                                 |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b>Crime and Law Enforcement</b>     | Bias or incomplete coverage     |
| <b>Environment</b>                   | Not enough coverage             |
| <b>Education</b>                     | Lack of consistency in coverage |
| <b>Health Care</b>                   | Incomplete coverage             |
| <b>Housing, Zoning, and Land Use</b> | Inconsistent coverage           |
| <b>Business and Employment</b>       | Incomplete or biased            |
| <b>Transportation</b>                | Inconsistent coverage           |
| <b>Cultural Opportunities</b>        | Lack of information             |

Although bias emerged as one concern, many of the testimonials instead focused on structural issues or concerns over availability. Concerning Housing, Zoning, and Land Use, one respondent noted: “My local news source...is severely understaffed...news about current events, e.g. city council, school board, etc., doesn’t appear until several days after the event, if then.” Another respondent noted: “Local news barely exists anymore.”

These responses indicate a recognition of the importance of local news, and reflect the eagerness with which consumers are prepared to engage with local news. The issues communicated about news are, by and large, not those of trust or saturation, but rather completion, accessibility, and relevance.

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## Quality of Coverage

Respondents were asked how good of a job local news does keeping them informed on issues

■ Positive ■ Neutral ■ Negative

### Crime and Law Enforcement



### Environment



### Education



### Health Care



### Housing, Zoning, and Land Use



### Business and Employment



### Transportation



### Cultural Opportunities



## Willingness to Pay

One of the starkest datapoints from the previous survey in 2021 was that 71% of respondents answered the question of “How do you feel generally about paying for local news?” with “No one should pay for local news.” This is a sharp difference from the 2023 Accelerator surveys: when asked the same question, only 37% gave the same answer. Furthermore, in 2021, just 6% suggested that “Everyone should pay,” compared to 22% in 2023.

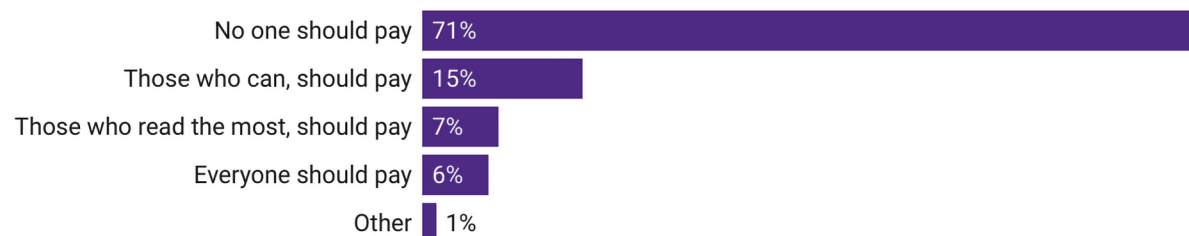
### Who Should Pay for News

Respondents were asked how they feel generally about paying for local news



### Who Should Pay for News (2021)

Respondents were asked how they feel generally about paying for local news



Even when adjusting for demographic factors like age, the disparity remains: in 2021, almost 40% of respondents under 35 agreed that no one should pay for news, and in 2023, that percentage was less than five.

These sentiments are corroborated by whether respondents actually do pay for local news or not. In 2021, the survey indicated, predictably, that 79% of respondents did not pay for local news. In 2023, that number was only 34%. Additionally, of respondents who currently pay for local news, more than 60% pay for access to two or more news sites.

## Conclusion

The 2023 Accelerator cohort has access to an audience that is, on the whole, excited about and invested in local news. Eschewing national trends, this audience is consuming local news about their communities more closely and more often than in previous years, and trust it as an invaluable source of information about their communities and the issues facing them. Recognizing the value of local reporting, consumers in this audience are willing to pay, and demonstrate that they do pay, for access to local news coverage. Furthermore, their general criticisms or observed shortcomings reflect this eagerness for expanded and sustained news coverage.